



Punching above weight: Defying expectations, India exceeded expectations once again, reaching the final before losing to World No. 15 Iran. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

In the crossover round, India defeated Pakistan 3-0 to book a place in the semifinals, while Iran overpowered Kazakhstan with the same margin.

The match against Pakistan was emotionally charged. After the win, several Indian players carried the national flag around the venue in celebration.

"A lot of emotions were there and against Pakistan, such emotions are always there. Because, you know about India-Pakistan and the recent issues between the two countries, we had to beat them and qualify for semifinals. The Indian fans were there and they supported us, by chanting 'Vande Mataram', Ashwal recalled.

Against Kazakhstan in the semifinals, India was visibly fatigued following the intense Pakistan clash the night before.

"Our match against Pakistan was in the evening and by the time we finished and reached the hotel it was pretty late in the night. We were a bit tired. We used our bench strength against Kazakhstan. And it worked. It

was purely a team effort," said Jerome.

Head coach Dragan emphasised the need for structural support to close the gap with teams like Iran.

He pointed out that Iran's B-team — composed of medal-winning youth, junior, and Under-21 players — participated in the CAVA League.

"The biggest difference is the international experience and the duration of the Iranian league. Their players play between 50 and 75 strong matches per year, for which we need another five to ten years!" he told *Sportstar*. On the road ahead, Dragan was clear.

"The recipe is very simple — to keep the team together for a longer time and give it the opportunity to play more friendly and official matches. We have the potential to be a top-25 team in the world."

The 62-year-old coach had one final note that spoke for the entire squad.

"All the 24 players (who were at the national camp in Bengaluru for the CAVA Men's Nations League) selected deserve better treatment."



INDIA RESULTS:

Gold medal match: Iran bt India 25-17, 25-20, 25-17; Bronze medal: Pakistan bt Kazakhstan 25-19, 23-25, 25-16, 25-22.

Pool 'A': Iran bt India 20-25, 25-19, 25-19, 25-22; India bt Uzbekistan 25-18, 25-16, 25-20; India bt Turkmenistan 27-29, 25-21, 25-19, 25-18;

Crossover round: India bt Pakistan 25-15, 25-19, 25-23; Semifinals: India bt Kazakhstan 26-24, 23-25, 25-21, 15-13.